

Salman Adnan Site

Brief: the whole project in one sitting

Digitalise Agency

2026-08-11

Contents

1	What it is, and two things to know first	2
1.1	Read it beside its twin	2
2	The mental model	3
3	How it works, end to end	3
4	The main components	4
4.1	index.html: the page	4
4.2	site.css: the design system	4
4.3	main.js: the three behaviours	4
4.4	The three files about hosting	5
5	How it is operated	5
5.1	Looking at it locally	5
5.2	Publishing	5
5.3	Claude Code tooling	5
6	Configuration and deployment at a glance	6
7	Honest findings	6
7.1	Unfinished	6
7.2	The rebrand to orange was left half done	6
7.3	Dead code	7
7.4	Content and consistency	7
7.5	Accessibility	7
7.6	One finding that belongs to a third repository	7
8	The story, in brief	7
8.1	What it delivered	8
8.2	When it was built	8
8.3	The four challenges that mattered	8
8.4	Where it stands	8
8.5	Do and do not	8
8.6	What would change, starting over	9
8.7	Open threads	9
9	Glossary	9

1 What it is, and two things to know first

This repository holds a personal brand website for **salmanadnan.com**: one page introducing Salman Adnan, showing six client projects, and asking the visitor to book a thirty-minute call.

Six files, 1,180 lines, no framework, no build step, no package manager, no database, no server code. That is unusual enough in 2026 to be worth stating as a decision rather than an absence.

First: this is not the page being served at that address

The design here was finished, then deliberately parked. On 2026-07-29 one commit moved every file into a folder called **new-design-reference/** and renamed the publishing workflow so it could no longer run. Its message says why: the live site is served from a different repository. Fetching <https://salmanadnan.com/> on 2026-08-11 confirms it. The address answers with 200 from the same VPS this project deploys to, and serves a page with a different title, a proper social preview image, and none of this version's distinctive markup. Read this repository as a design reference, never as the live site.

Second: the design was never finished, and it says so on screen

The left half of the hero, which is half of everything visible when the page loads, contains no photograph. It contains a giant letter **S** on an orange gradient and the words *“Drop Salman’s photo here / assets/salman.jpg”*.

That is not a code comment. It is content, deliberately styled and positioned, and any visitor would read it. On a personal brand page, whose entire proposition is a person, the missing element is the person. This is why the honest description of this project is “unfinished” rather than “finished and parked”.

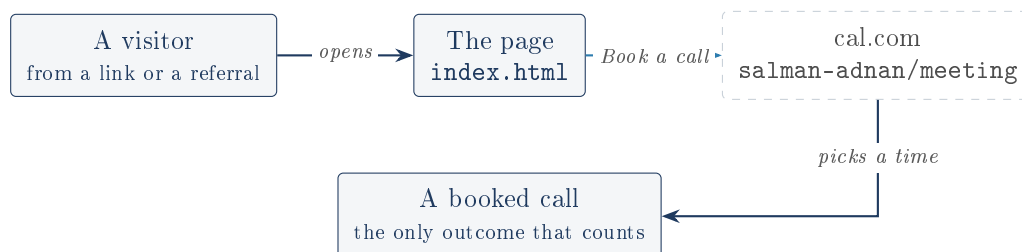


Figure 1: The entire purpose. Dashed boxes are services the agency does not run.

1.1 Read it beside its twin

There is a near-identical sibling in this workspace, **ai-digitalise**, built the same week from the same skeleton: the same six file paths, the same three-file architecture, the same publishing workflow and the same fate. They are not copies; every substantive file differs. This one is a personal page in orange, that one an agency service page in blue.

Comparing them teaches more than reading either alone, and the Deep Dive points out each instructive difference where it arises.

2 The mental model

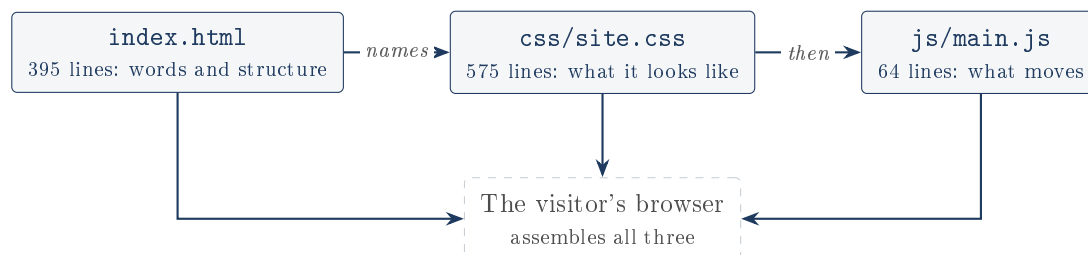


Figure 2: Nothing runs on a server. Everything happens on the visitor's machine.

The arrows only point one way, and one of them is already broken

`index.html` names the other two files. Neither knows anything about it: the stylesheet styles class names it hopes exist, and the JavaScript looks for elements that may not be there, guarding every lookup so it does nothing quietly when they are missing. Nothing checks that the three agree, and in one place they do not. Three stylesheet rules target a class the HTML never uses, so they have never once applied. The page looks correct anyway, because the HTML achieves the same layout by a different means. Nothing anywhere reported it. That is what “silent failure” means in practice.

3 How it works, end to end

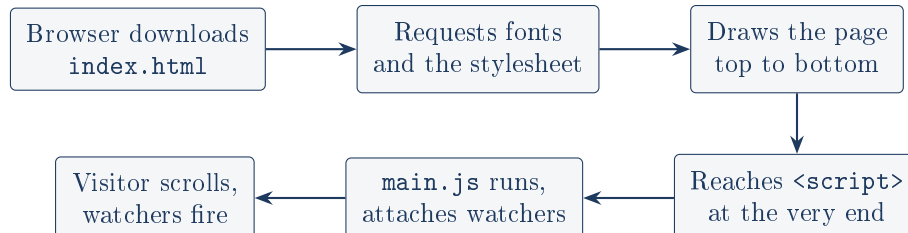


Figure 3: One page view, start to finish.

The page stacks six bands: a fixed navigation bar; a two-column hero with the photo frame on the left, three drifting frosted badges over it, and the name, tagline, buttons and three small statistics on the right; a grid of six client projects; four large counting numbers; two case-study cards; a booking panel; and a footer.

Three things react to scrolling, and that is the whole of the interactivity: the navigation bar gains a frosted background past 40 pixels of scroll, the four large numbers count up from zero over 2.2 seconds when they come into view, and most blocks fade upward as they arrive.

There is no form, nothing is saved, and nothing is sent anywhere. The only outbound action is following the booking link, which opens a `cal.com` calendar in a new tab.

Nothing measures whether the page works

No analytics of any kind: no counter, no tag manager, no event when somebody presses “Book a call”. The one question the page exists to answer cannot be answered from the page. The live `salmanadnan.com` does carry a full social-preview setup this version lacks, so whoever built the replacement thought about distribution in a way this design did not.

4 The main components

File	Kind	Lines	What it does
<code>new-design-reference/index.html</code>	HTML	395	Every word on the page and its structure, with all icons as inline drawings
<code>new-design-reference/css/site.css</code>	CSS	575	All appearance, layout, movement, and the two mobile layouts
<code>new-design-reference/js/main.js</code>	JavaScript	64	The three scroll behaviours, no dependencies
<code>new-design-reference/netlify.toml</code>	config	11	Hosting settings for a host this project does not use
<code>new-design-reference/assets/ASSETS.md</code>	notes	32	A checklist of eleven assets, none of which were produced
<code>.github/workflows-disabled/deploy.yml.disabled</code>	workflow	103	The publishing pipeline, switched off

Table 1: Every file git tracks. The Deep Dive walks all six line by line, in sections 7.1 to 7.6.

4.1 `index.html`: the page

The content and structure. Unusually self-contained: every icon is an SVG drawing written directly into the file rather than loaded as an image, so the page needs no image downloads at all.

Two habits are worth knowing before editing it. Appearance is sometimes written directly onto elements with `style` attributes rather than left to the stylesheet, and an inline style always wins. And the four large statistics keep their real values in `data-` attributes with a visible 0, so they read as zero until JavaScript runs. Deep Dive section 7.1.

4.2 `site.css`: the design system

The most valuable file here, and the one worth borrowing. It opens with nineteen named values, the “tokens”, covering surfaces, text, accents, borders, typefaces, radii, a motion curve and a content width. Its own second line records the lineage: the tokens are shared with `ai.digitalise.agency`.

Why the token names are numbers rather than colours

Calling a colour `-s1` instead of `-dark-navy` names what it is *for* (the surface one step up from the page) rather than how it looks. This pair of repositories proves the point: the two stylesheets share every token *name* and differ in nearly every token *value*, so one vocabulary produced a blue agency site and an orange personal one with no renaming at all.

It ends with the best thing in the project: a block honouring the visitor’s reduced-motion preference, which crushes every animation, forces the fade-in elements to full opacity so they still appear, and explicitly stops the drifting badges. That is more careful than the sibling’s equivalent. Deep Dive section 7.2.

4.3 `main.js`: the three behaviours

Sixty-four lines, no dependencies, better written than its size suggests: a wrapper keeping its names private, a guard at every lookup, a small shared helper built on `IntersectionObserver` that three one-line calls reuse, and correct use of the flags that keep scrolling smooth and stop each animation firing twice.

Its interface with the rest of the project is six strings. Break any one and the page keeps working, minus one behaviour, silently. Deep Dive section 7.3.

4.4 The three files about hosting

`netlify.toml` declares four sensible security headers for a hosting service this project does not use, and is byte for byte identical to the sibling's copy. `ASSETS.md` lists the eleven assets needed to finish the design, none of which exist. The workflow publishes to the agency's server when a commit subject begins with `[deploy]`, and is switched off. Deep Dive sections 7.4 to 7.6.

5 How it is operated

5.1 Looking at it locally

```
1 cd new-design-reference
2 python3 -m http.server 8000
3 # then open http://localhost:8000/
```

Listing 1: Serve it, do not open the file directly

Opening `index.html` straight off the disk renders it completely unstyled, which looks like catastrophic breakage and is not. The page asks for its stylesheet at `/css/site.css`, and the leading slash means “from the top of the site”, which off a disk is the root of your hard drive. This one character is the most likely thing to make a newcomer think the project is broken.

5.2 Publishing

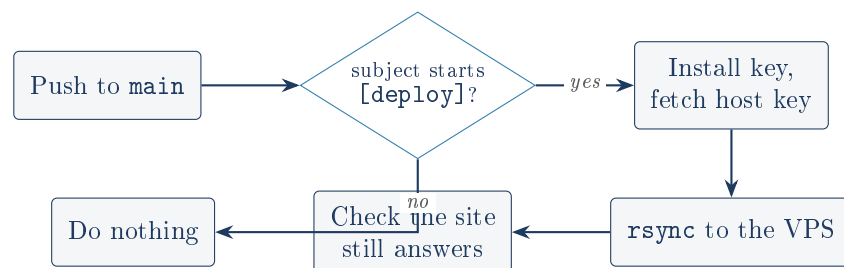


Figure 4: The publishing pipeline as written. Switched off, twice over, since 2026-07-29.

The `[deploy]` marker must *begin* the commit subject line. Writing “fix the header and `[deploy]`” does nothing at all. This convention is shared by every repository in this workspace.

The workflow is disabled two ways: its folder is `.github/workflows-disabled` rather than `.github/workflows`, and the file ends `.disabled` rather than `.yaml`. Either alone would suffice, which tells you the intent was not to pause it briefly.

Restoring it unchanged would take the live site down

The `rsync` command copies the repository root, which since the move contains a folder rather than a home page, and it copies with `-delete`. So it would replace the live `salmanadnan.com` with a directory listing's worth of nothing. The correct source after the move is `new-design-reference/`.

5.3 Claude Code tooling

This project ships none, which was checked rather than assumed: no `.claude/` folder, no `CLAUDE.md`, no skill and no hook.

There is no README either, and that matters more than it sounds. The central fact about this repository, that it is parked and the live site is elsewhere, exists only in a commit message, invisible unless somebody thinks to run `git log`. The same gap exists in the sibling.

The two PDFs in `docs/explainer/` are produced by a workspace-level command, `/explain-projects`, living outside this repository.

6 Configuration and deployment at a glance

Nothing is configurable at run time: no settings file, no environment file. Three values behave like configuration and are written into the source:

Value	Where	Controls
<code>https://cal.com/salman-adnan/meeting</code>	<code>index.html</code> line 362	which calendar opens
<code>salman@digitalise.agency</code>	<code>index.html</code> line 386	the footer contact
The nineteen tokens	<code>site.css</code> lines 5–25	the entire colour scheme

Table 2: Values that behave like settings.

The repository holds no passwords, keys or tokens, and should not: a page running entirely in a visitor’s browser can keep no secret. Three secrets live in GitHub and are referenced by the workflow (`VPS_HOST`, `VPS_USER`, `VPS_SSH_KEY`); the server’s IP address is also written into a comment in that same file, which defeats the point of storing it as a secret.

The page has two run-time dependencies, both reached by the visitor’s browser: Google Fonts for two typefaces, and `cal.com` for the booking calendar.

7 Honest findings

7.1 Unfinished

- **The hero photo is a visible placeholder** reading “Drop Salman’s photo here”. The finding that matters most.
- **None of the eleven assets in `ASSETS.md` exist**: no photograph, no project thumbnails, no case-study screenshots, no favicon, no social preview image. The live replacement site has at least the last of these.
- **Seven stale comments** remain in `index.html`, some describing work that was done and some work that was not.

7.2 The rebrand to orange was left half done

Five rules still use the agency blue

Commit `05210af` is titled “Differentiate to orange brand”. The tokens were duly changed. Five rules further down still hard-code the agency blue rather than reading the token:

Line	Rule	What a visitor sees
65	<code>.btn-primary:hover</code>	an orange button casting a blue shadow
255–256	<code>.hero-tag</code>	a blue-tinted pill containing orange text
337	<code>.work-card:hover</code>	a project card outlined in blue on hover
435	<code>.case-card:hover</code>	the same on the case-study cards
498	<code>.book-wrap::before</code>	a blue glow above the booking panel

Orange and blue are close to complementary, so the shadow under the button reads as a mistake rather than a choice. All five are one-line fixes. Together they are a clean illustration of what the token system is for: the rebrand changed the tokens and could not reach the literals. Notably it *did* reach the six thumbnail gradients, which tells you it was done by eye rather than by search.

7.3 Dead code

Three stylesheet rules for a reversal class the HTML never uses, which have never applied and whose job is done by inline `order` properties instead; four tokens defined and never read, including the agency blue that five other rules write out as a literal; a class added by JavaScript that nothing styles; and a whole hosting configuration file for a host that is not used.

7.4 Content and consistency

The three hero statistics duplicate three of the four in the metrics band, written as plain text in one place and as data attributes in the other. `ASSETS.md` knows this and says to update both, so it is a documented trade rather than an accident, and it accidentally rescues the page from claiming zero of everything when JavaScript does not run.

Two of the three instructions in `ASSETS.md` are stale. The six project cards show a play button on hover and play nothing. The navigation logo is not a link.

7.5 Accessibility

- **The counting numbers ignore the reduced-motion preference.** The stylesheet honours it more carefully than the sibling does; the JavaScript never checks. Four lines fix it, given in Deep Dive section 7.3.
- **Neither button has a focus state**, so keyboard navigation relies on whatever outline the browser draws, often nearly invisible on a dark background. These are the page's only interactive elements.
- **The small orange uppercase labels are worth a contrast measurement.** This document does not have one and raises it rather than asserting a failure.

7.6 One finding that belongs to a third repository

The live `ai.digitalise.agency` claims this domain as its canonical

The page live at `ai.digitalise.agency` declares `<link rel="canonical" href="https://salmanadnan.com/">`, which asks search engines to index this domain instead of that one. The live `salmanadnan.com` declares its own canonical correctly, and both are served from the same VPS.

So the agency page was produced from this personal site's build and its canonical link was never changed. Neither repository in this pair can fix it, because neither contains the live build. It is recorded in both documents so whoever maintains the portfolio repository finds it. Verified by fetching both addresses on 2026-08-11.

8 The story, in brief

8.1 What it delivered

A complete, self-contained one-page personal brand website with no dependencies to install; a hosting configuration setting four security headers; a GitHub Actions workflow publishing over SSH with two retry loops and a post-deploy check; and an asset checklist. What it did not deliver is a live site, or a photograph.

8.2 When it was built

Ten commits across two calendar days, 2026-07-28 and 2026-07-29, and nothing since. The shape of that history is the interesting part: four commits on day one building the thing, five consecutive commits on day two fighting the deploy, and one commit switching it off.

This is calendar time, not effort. Git records when commits happened and nothing about hours spent, and no document here records effort, so none is claimed.

8.3 The four challenges that mattered

Each is claimed because the repository carries a scar for it.

1. **SSH access to the server**, across three commits: secrets missing, then the wrong key, then a `deploy` user without permission to traverse into `/root`. That last is genuinely unobvious and its workaround survives in three `rsync` flags.
2. **GitHub's runners being refused**, across two more. One is titled “Retry, runner IP lottery”, which is the diagnosis stated outright. This repository is where the evidence lives; the sibling has the same retry loops and no commit explaining them.
3. **Deciding what the brand was**. One commit exists solely to differentiate this site from the agency's blue, and it reached the tokens while missing five literals: the trace of a decision made after the design was written rather than before.
4. **Being overtaken**. The final commit is a retreat, not a fix. The page was finished and working when something else became the live site. The largest event here, and not technical.

8.4 Where it stands

Built and unfinished: it renders, it is responsive, and the most prominent element on the page is still a request for a photograph. Parked deliberately, with the workflow disabled twice over. Superseded by a build that has a proper title, a correct canonical link and a social preview image. One thing survived: the booking link set here is the same one the live site uses today. Dormant since 2026-07-29.

8.5 Do and do not

From here on this is advice and judgement, not a record of decisions.

Do:

- Read `git log` before touching anything: it holds the only statement of this repository's status.
- Serve the folder over HTTP to view it, never open the file directly.
- Read it beside `ai-digitalise`. The differences between the two are where the interesting decisions are.
- Keep the `[deploy]` convention and both retry loops if the workflow is ever restored. They were paid for over five commits.
- Treat the hero as the reusable asset: a two-column layout with fading edges and drifting frosted badges, in about eighty lines of CSS.

Do not:

- Re-enable the workflow without changing the `rsync` source path. It would copy a folder rather than a page, with `-delete` set, and take the live site down.
- Publish this design without the photograph.
- Trust `ASSETS.md`. Two of its three instructions refer to things no longer in the code, or never there.
- Fix the five blue literals by changing the token. The token is correct and the literals are wrong; changing `-accent` back to blue would make five rules consistent and the entire site wrong.
- Assume this repository is what visitors see. It is not.

8.6 What would change, starting over

Opinion, argued from the code. Keep the no-build-step decision, the token block, the three-behaviour JavaScript, the reduced-motion handling and the two-column hero. For a page this size every one is right, and a framework would have added a hundred times the machinery for nothing a visitor could perceive.

Change five things. Get the photograph first, because a personal brand page without a photograph of the person is not a draft of the design, it is a draft of the idea. Write a README on day one. Use a relative stylesheet path. Never write a colour literally when a token exists, which would have made the rebrand a one-line change instead of a six-line one with five missed. Write the real numbers into the HTML and let the counter animate towards them.

Drop `netlify.toml`, or move its four security headers into the Caddy configuration on the VPS where they would actually take effect, and drop the four unused tokens.

8.7 Open threads

Eleven assets never delivered, the photograph above all; five blue literals on an orange site; three dead stylesheet rules; seven stale comments; the canonical link on the live `ai.digitalise.agency` pointing at this domain; and an undocumented sibling relationship between two repositories that share a skeleton.

9 Glossary

ARIA

Attributes beginning `aria-` describing a page to screen readers. They change nothing visually.

Breakpoint

A screen width at which the layout changes. This project has two, at 960 and 600 pixels.

Canonical URL

A declaration of where content authoritatively lives, used by search engines to avoid indexing it twice.

Class

A label attached to elements so CSS and JavaScript can find them.

clamp

A CSS function taking a minimum, a preferred value and a maximum, used so headings scale with the window between fixed limits.

CSS

Cascading Style Sheets: the file controlling appearance.

Custom property

A named value in CSS, written `-name` and read with `var(-name)`. The “tokens” are these.

Data attribute

An attribute beginning `data-` that HTML ignores and JavaScript can read.

Flexbox

A layout system arranging children in a row or a column.

Grid

A layout system arranging children in rows and columns at once.

HTML

HyperText Markup Language: content and structure.

IntersectionObserver

A browser facility reporting when an element scrolls into view. All three scroll behaviours are built on it.

JavaScript

The language running in the browser after the page loads.

Media query

CSS applying only when a condition about the screen is true.

object-fit

A CSS property controlling how an image fills a frame it does not exactly match. `ASSETS.md` specifies it for the missing photograph.

order

A CSS property setting an item’s position inside a flex or grid container, independent of its position in the HTML. It is what actually reverses the second case-study card.

prefers-reduced-motion

A system setting asking pages to avoid animation, usually because it causes nausea or migraine. The stylesheet honours it; the JavaScript does not.

Pseudo-element

An extra box CSS creates with no tag in the HTML, written `::before` or `::after`, used here for the hero’s fading edges and the glow above the booking panel.

rsync

A program copying files between computers, transferring only what differs.

Selector

The part of a CSS rule saying which elements it applies to.

SSH

Secure Shell: the standard way to connect to another computer securely.

SVG

A picture described as shapes and coordinates rather than pixels, so it stays sharp at any size and can sit inside the HTML file.

Token

In this project, one of the nineteen named values at the top of the stylesheet.

VPS

Virtual Private Server: a rented computer controlled remotely. This project's is at 46.202.194.85, which salmanadnan.com resolves to today.

Workflow

A file describing a job GitHub runs automatically when something happens in the repository.

For the full treatment, including every line of every file with its provenance, its connections and its failure modes, see `docs/explainer/deep-dive.pdf` in this same folder.